SACRED SEASONS · ADVENT 2026

Week 4: Love That Says Yes

December 20 to 24 · Spiritual practices for small groups and personal prayer

> **This week's prayer**
>
> *God, let me say my own yes with Mary, freely and with my questions intact.*

HOW TO USE THESE PRACTICES

- This week has four passages for Lectio Divina (pray one each day, or choose one for a gathering) and two practices to lead with a small group or pray on your own. Each takes 10 to 20 minutes.
- If you are leading a group, read the steps aloud slowly. Let the silences be long enough to feel a little long.
- Offer the questions as invitations. No one has to answer out loud, and there are no wrong answers.
- Every practice is also in the free Sacred Seasons app, where you can read it or listen as Dr. Julene guides you: sacredseasons.julenetegerstrand.com

BEFORE YOU LEAD

Leaders are asked for many yeses in December. Which of yours are freely given? What question would you like to ask before your next yes?

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Written by Julene Tegerstrand. She developed these practices over many drafts, working with Claude (Anthropic's AI assistant) on wording and layout, and then edited them herself in several passes. The final text is hers, reviewed and approved by the author.

PRAY WITH SCRIPTURE: LECTIO DIVINA

Luke 1:35-38

Lectio Divina means sacred reading. Read the passage aloud four times, slowly. After each reading, keep some silence with the invitation. In a group, a different person can read each time. Choose whether you have people share their words, thoughts out loud or if they do this in silence. If you do each round in silence, give a time for people to share their experience after the prayer experience concludes.

The angel Gabriel has greeted Mary. She has been perplexed, and she has pondered. She has asked her own question, "How can this be?", and the angel has answered her. Now she speaks.

> 35 *The angel said to her, "The Holy Spirit will come upon you, and the power of the Most High will overshadow you; therefore the child to be born will be holy; he will be called Son of God. 36 And now, your relative Elizabeth in her old age has also conceived a son, and this is the sixth month for her who was said to be barren. 37 For nothing will be impossible with God." 38 Then Mary said, "Here am I, the servant of the Lord; let it be with me according to your word." Then the angel departed from her.*
>
> Luke 1:35-38 (NRSVue)

First reading. Listen for one word or phrase that catches you. You don't need to know why it catches you. Just notice it.

Second reading. Listen again to the passage. You might consider one of these questions in silence. What is being asked of you right now? What would it mean to say, "Here am I"? Notice that Mary asked her question first. *(If leading a group, read the instructions, read the passage, read the questions again and give enough silence for reflection.)*

Third reading. What do you want to say to God? You might say yes. You might ask your own question. You might say, "I am still pondering." Any of these is a real prayer.

Fourth reading. Now rest. Christmas is coming, and God is coming close. You don't have to do anything more to be ready.

Carry with you: *"Here am I, the servant of the Lord; let it be with me according to your word."*

Try this: Today, before you say yes to anything, take one breath and ask, "Is this mine to carry?"

PRAY WITH SCRIPTURE: LECTIO DIVINA

2 Samuel 7:5-7, 11

Lectio Divina means sacred reading. Read the passage aloud four times, slowly. After each reading, keep some silence with the invitation. In a group, a different person can read each time. Choose whether you have people share their words, thoughts out loud or if they do this in silence. If you do each round in silence, give a time for people to share their experience after the prayer experience concludes.

King David is settled in his palace and wants to build God a house. That night God turns the question around. God doesn't need David to build anything. God will build David a house: a family, a household that lasts.

> 5 *"Go and tell my servant David: Thus says the Lord: Are you the one to build me a house to live*
> *in? 6 I have not lived in a house since the day I brought up the people of Israel from Egypt to*
> *this day, but I have been moving about in a tent and a tabernacle. 7 Wherever I have moved*
> *about among all the people of Israel, did I ever speak a word with any of the tribal leaders of*
> *Israel, whom I commanded to shepherd my people Israel, saying, 'Why have you not built me*
> *a house of cedar?'*
>
> . . .
>
> 11 *Moreover, the Lord declares to you that the Lord will make you a house.*
>
> 2 Samuel 7:5-7, 11 (NRSVue)

First reading. Listen for one word or phrase that catches you. You don't need to know why it catches you. Just notice it.

Second reading. Listen again to the passage. You might consider one of these questions in silence. What are you trying to build for God this season? What might God be building for you? *(If leading a group, read the instructions, read the passage, read the questions again and give enough silence for reflection.)*

Third reading. What do you want to say to God? You might tell God what you've been working so hard to build. You might ask God to do the building.

Fourth reading. Now rest. You already belong. God is the one who builds the house.

Carry with you: *"The Lord will make you a house."*

Try this: Today, before you take on one more task, pray one line: "Lord, you build it."

PRAY WITH SCRIPTURE: LECTIO DIVINA

Luke 1:46b-49

Lectio Divina means sacred reading. Read the passage aloud four times, slowly. After each reading, keep some silence with the invitation. In a group, a different person can read each time. Choose whether you have people share their words, thoughts out loud or if they do this in silence. If you do each round in silence, give a time for people to share their experience after the prayer experience concludes.

Mary has gone to visit her relative Elizabeth. When Elizabeth blesses her, Mary sings. She is a young woman from a poor village in an occupied land, and she sings that God has looked on her with favor.

> 46 *"My soul magnifies the Lord,*
> 47 *and my spirit rejoices in God my Savior,*
> 48 *for he has looked with favor on the lowly state of his servant.*
> *Surely from now on all generations will call me blessed,*
> 49 *for the Mighty One has done great things for me,*
> *and holy is his name.*
>
> Luke 1:46b-49 (NRSVue)

First reading. Listen for one word or phrase that catches you. You don't need to know why it catches you. Just notice it.

Second reading. Listen again to the passage. You might consider one of these questions in silence. What great things has God done for you? Where do you feel lowly, and what would it mean to be looked on with favor? *(If leading a group, read the instructions, read the passage, read the questions again and give enough silence for reflection.)*

Third reading. What do you want to say to God? You might sing your own song of thanks. You might tell God where you are still waiting to be lifted up.

Fourth reading. Now rest. God has looked on you with favor, and sees you.

Carry with you: *"My soul magnifies the Lord."*

Try this: Today, ask an elder you trust what they have seen God do in their life, and listen.

PRAY WITH SCRIPTURE: LECTIO DIVINA

Romans 16:25-27

Lectio Divina means sacred reading. Read the passage aloud four times, slowly. After each reading, keep some silence with the invitation. In a group, a different person can read each time. Choose whether you have people share their words, thoughts out loud or if they do this in silence. If you do each round in silence, give a time for people to share their experience after the prayer experience concludes.

On Christmas Eve we hear the very end of Paul's letter to the Romans. Paul closes with praise for a mystery kept secret for long ages and now disclosed. Tonight the church celebrates that mystery: God with us.

> 25 *Now to God who is able to strengthen you according to my gospel and the proclamation of Jesus Christ, according to the revelation of the mystery that was kept secret for long ages 26 but is now disclosed and through the prophetic writings is made known to all the gentiles, according to the command of the eternal God, to bring about the obedience of faith— 27 to the only wise God, through Jesus Christ, to whom be the glory forever! Amen.*
>
> Romans 16:25-27 (NRSVue)

First reading. Listen for one word or phrase that catches you. You don't need to know why it catches you. Just notice it.

Second reading. Listen again to the passage. You might consider one of these questions in silence. What about God is still a mystery to you tonight? What is being disclosed to you this Christmas? *(If leading a group, read the instructions, read the passage, read the questions again and give enough silence for reflection.)*

Third reading. What do you want to say to God? You might give glory. You might say you don't understand. Either is a true prayer on this holy night.

Fourth reading. Now rest in the mystery. It needs no explaining tonight. Christ is coming close.

Carry with you: *"To the only wise God, through Jesus Christ, to whom be the glory forever!"*

Try this: Tonight, before Christmas fills everything with sound, keep one minute of silence with the mystery.

A PRACTICE FOR A SMALL GROUP

The Wide View and the Small Room

Personal or group · 20 minutes



This is an old and beloved way of praying the Christmas story. First you imagine God looking with love at the whole world, every kind of person and place. Then the gaze narrows to one small house in Nazareth, where an angel greets a young woman. That scene is this Sunday's Gospel.

God is found in real places and real lives. It helps to picture Mary as she likely was: a young Jewish woman in a small village in Galilee, under Roman rule, far from anyone's idea of importance. This practice lets you see Christmas from God's side first.

> 26 *In the sixth month the angel Gabriel was sent by God to a town in Galilee called Nazareth, 27 to a virgin engaged to a man whose name was Joseph, of the house of David. The virgin's name was Mary. 28 And he came to her and said, "Greetings, favored one! The Lord is with you." 29 But she was much perplexed by his words and pondered what sort of greeting this might be. 30 The angel said to her, "Do not be afraid, Mary, for you have found favor with God. 31 And now, you will conceive in your womb and bear a son, and you will name him Jesus. 32 He will be great and will be called the Son of the Most High, and the Lord God will give to him the throne of his ancestor David. 33 He will reign over the house of Jacob forever, and of his kingdom there will be no end." 34 Mary said to the angel, "How can this be, since I am a virgin?" 35 The angel said to her, "The Holy Spirit will come upon you, and the power of the Most High will overshadow you; therefore the child to be born will be holy; he will be called Son of God. 36 And now, your relative Elizabeth in her old age has also conceived a son, and this is the sixth month for her who was said to be barren. 37 For nothing will be impossible with God." 38 Then Mary said, "Here am I, the servant of the Lord; let it be with me according to your word." Then the angel departed from her.*
>
> Luke 1:26-38 (NRSVue)

STEPS

1. The wide view. Picture the whole earth as God sees it this December: hospitals and border crossings, kitchens and refugee camps, cities and farms, your own street. Hear the many languages. People are laughing and weeping, being born and dying. Notice how God looks at all of it.
2. Imagine God, Jesus Christ, and the Holy Spirit deciding together to come close, to enter this world from the inside.
3. The small room. Now read Luke 1:26-38 slowly. See the small room in Nazareth. See the people. Hear what they say. Watch what they do.
4. Notice that Mary is perplexed, that she ponders, that she asks a real question, and that the angel answers before she says yes.

5. Speak with Mary, or with Jesus, about whatever stirred in you. Speak as you would to someone you trust.
6. Close with the Lord's Prayer, in whatever language you first learned it.

QUESTIONS TO PRAY WITH OR SHARE

- What did I feel as I imagined God looking at the whole world with love?
- Where did my own people, my own place, show up in the wide view?
- What surprised me about Mary?
- What question would I want to ask God right now, the way Mary did?

WITH A GROUP, HOUSEHOLD, OR CHILDREN

A leader reads the steps slowly, with long pauses. An audio version works well for this practice, so people can listen without reading.

> **A word of care.** If imagining is hard or makes you anxious, read the passage slowly and stop at any word that holds you. Picturing yourself being loved can feel uncomfortable, especially if you've been hurt. Feeling nothing is okay too. The world scenes can also touch real grief about war or displacement. You can keep the wide view brief.

A PRACTICE FOR A SMALL GROUP

Keeping Silence with the Mystery

Personal or group · 10 minutes



Paul ends Romans with praise for "the mystery that was kept secret for long ages but is now disclosed." Mary, too, pondered what she couldn't yet explain.

Christians pray in many ways. Some churches pray aloud all at once, some sing, some keep long silences. We often fill our prayers with words that comfort us. This practice leaves room for the mystery, before Christmas fills everything with noise.

> 25 *Now to God who is able to strengthen you according to my gospel and the proclamation of Jesus Christ, according to the revelation of the mystery that was kept secret for long ages 26 but is now disclosed and through the prophetic writings is made known to all the gentiles, according to the command of the eternal God, to bring about the obedience of faith— 27 to the only wise God, through Jesus Christ, to whom be the glory forever! Amen.*
>
> Romans 16:25-27 (NRSVue)

STEPS

1. Set a timer for five minutes.
2. Sit in silence, without words.
3. When thoughts come, let them come. You can let them be instead of fighting them, and then let them pass.
4. When the timer sounds, read the doxology aloud once.
5. Sit for one more minute. Say, "Amen."

QUESTIONS TO PRAY WITH OR SHARE

- What came up in the silence that I usually cover up with words?
- What about God is still a mystery to me, and how do I feel about that?
- What part of my own life can I not yet explain?
- What might it mean to trust God with what I don't understand?

WITH A GROUP, HOUSEHOLD, OR CHILDREN

In worship, this can come right before the benediction on the fourth Sunday of Advent.

> **A word of care.** Silence isn't restful for everyone. For some people it's where painful thoughts get loud. Keep your eyes open, walk, or play soft instrumental music. The point isn't about audible sound—it is to do something to create more stillness in ourselves. Allow our worries and anxieties to settle. Find a practice that helps you settle.

Sacred Seasons

A free Advent prayer app from spiritual director Rev. Dr. Julene Tegerstrand. One prayer each day from November 29 to Christmas Eve, to read or to hear. No ads, no account. You can sign up or find out more at sacredseasons.julenetegerstrand.com

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